

EAGER EMBRACE
Shivraj Chouhan during the Ambedkar Jayanti celebrations, Apr. 15

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pointment of Arun Sao, a community leader and Lok Sabha member from Bilaspur, as the state BJP president last year a case in point.

OBCs account for 50.1 per cent of MP's population, according to a recent submission made by the state government in court (on the basis of the 2011 census). But largely being an economic bloc instead of a social group, they don't vote en masse. And that's the reason the BJP government in MP, as the Congress government in Chhattisgarh, is targeting the OBC vote at "micro" level. "There had been a demand for granting representation to smaller OBC groups for quite some time," says BJP spokesperson Rahul Kothari, "and

ILLEGAL IMMIGRATION

AMERICAN DREAM TURNS NIGHTMARE

By Jumana Shah

In a tragic incident, a family of four from the Manekpura village in Gujarat's Mehsana district died while attempting to cross into the US from Canada, when the boat they were in capsized in the St Lawrence river. The bodies of Pravin Chaudhary (50), his wife Daksha (45), their son Meet (20) and daughter Vidhi (24) were found in a river marsh near the US-Canada border, along with the remains of another immigrant Romanian family who were on the same boat. This came less than 15 months after another family from the state— Jagdish Patel (39), his wife Vaishaliben (37) and children Vihangi (11) and Dharmik (3)—froze to death while illegally crossing the US-Canada border. Manekpura is just 25 km away from Dingucha, the village in Gandhinagar district where the Patels hailed from. Once again, the growing obsession in north Gujarat with the American soil as well as the thriving network of traffickers—or 'agents'—who are capitalising on it, have come under sharp focus.

"We have learnt during our investigation that at least 5,000 families have been sent to the US by such agents after the January 2022 Dingucha incident," said a senior police officer. "As long as there is demand, racketeers will continue to find innovative ways to dodge the law."

Usually operating under the guise of running 'study abroad', 'business visa' or 'career counselling' programmes, such agents charge anywhere between Rs 25 lakh and Rs 1.5 crore per person to help them reach the US. The police began cracking down on traffickers after the Dingucha case last year, but, says an activist, legal punishment is not an effective deterrent. In December last year, the police arrested Bobby alias Bharat Patel, a high-profile agent in Gujarat. However, a sessions court granted him bail and he was out within three weeks. Of the three other agents arrested in January this year, one, Bhavin Patel,

FAMILIES OFTEN TAKE PERILOUS ROUTES TO REACH THE US, BUT MAY NOT ALWAYS KNOW THE EXACT NATURE OF THE CHALLENGES